

Communicating Up

Building Confidence Across Generations

New Intern Onboarding Workshop
NorthStar Rail

Communication Challenge Lab



Communication Reality Check

What makes “communicating up” feel hard for new interns?

**You know the work.
Now make your message easy to act on.**

How formal should I be?

Will my question sound obvious?

How much detail is enough?

What if I get feedback?

Today is not a lecture.

It is a lab for testing better communication choices.



Choose



Rewrite



Practice



Commit

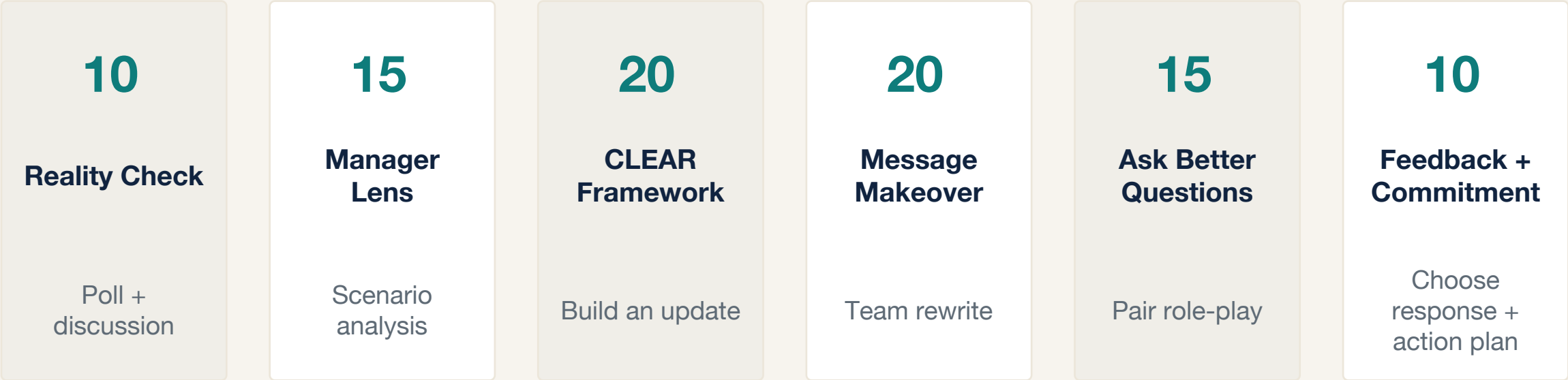
By the end, you will be able to...

Six practical outcomes for your first 30 days.

- 1 Read the manager lens: what leaders need from you**
- 2 Adapt tone by audience and channel**
- 3 Use CLEAR for updates, requests, and questions**
- 4 Ask specific questions without over-apologizing**
- 5 Respond to feedback with ownership**
- 6 Create a 30-day communication commitment**

90-Minute Challenge Map

Each section includes a quick action, not just listening.



The Communication Gap

The challenge is not age. It is expectation, context, and role.

Student / Peer Mode

- Fast, casual messages
- Lots of context or no context
- Questions asked late
- Feedback can feel personal

Manager / Leader Mode

- Purpose first
- Enough context to decide
- Specific ask or next step
- Feedback drives improvement

Goal: keep your authentic voice, but add structure.

Manager Lens

Before you hit send: what does your manager need to act?

Clear

Main point is easy to find

Concise

Only useful details

Timely

Raise issues early

Action-oriented

Decision, request, next step

Professional

Respectful and appropriate

Ownership-based

Shows preparation

Challenge 1: Manager Lens

Find what is missing from this message.

“Hi, I’m confused about the data. Can you help?”

1. What is unclear?
2. What would the manager still need to know?
3. How could this message be improved?

Small groups • 4 minutes

The CLEAR Framework

A repeatable structure for updates, requests, questions, and follow-up.

C

Context

What is the situation?

L

Lead with the point

What is the main message or request?

E

Explain briefly

What does the manager need to know?

A

Ask or action

What do you need, or what will you do next?

R

Recap next step

Confirm deadline, owner, or follow-up

From vague to manager-ready

Same question. Better structure.

Before

Hi, I'm confused about the data. Can you help?

After: CLEAR

Hi Alex, I'm working on the safety reporting draft due Thursday. I have one question about which data source to use for the incident-rate section. Could you confirm whether I should use the monthly dashboard or the year-to-date export? Once confirmed, I can complete the draft by Thursday afternoon.

Challenge 2: Build a CLEAR Update

Write it first. Improve it with a partner.

Your manager asked you to review a vendor proposal. You completed the review, but found two pricing items that need clarification before tomorrow’s team meeting.

1

Write your CLEAR message
3 min

2

Compare with a partner
4 min

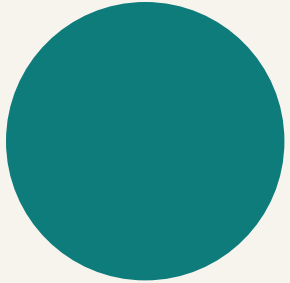
3

Share one stronger version
3 min

Use your worksheet

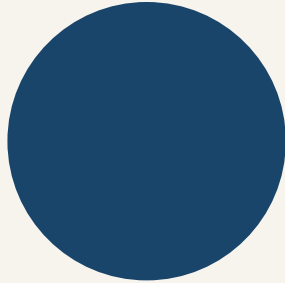
Professional tone is not robotic

It is clear, respectful, useful, concise, and confident.



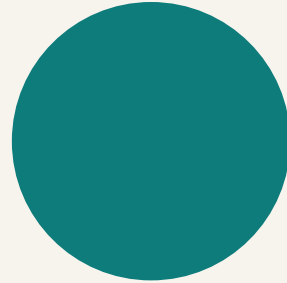
Respectful

Appropriate to the audience



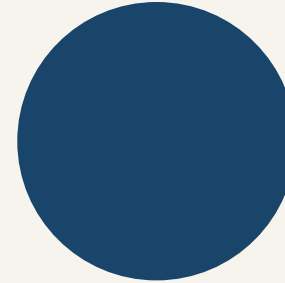
Clear

Easy to understand



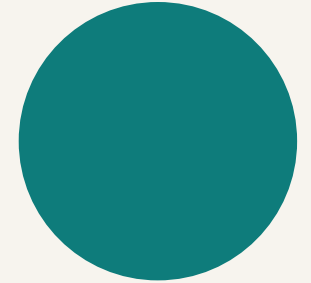
Useful

Helps the reader act



Concise

No unnecessary detail



Confident

Shows ownership

Ask: “What does the reader need to know, decide, or do?”

Challenge 3: Message Makeover

Turn a weak message into a senior-manager-ready message.

“Hey, just wondering if you saw my thing from yesterday lol. Need your thoughts when you can.”

Purpose clear

Professional tone

Specific request

Concise

Next step

Teams • 6 minutes

Speaking up: ask better questions

A clear question often shows preparation, not weakness.

- | | | |
|----------|-------------------------------|---|
| 1 | What I already did | I reviewed the project brief and checked the shared folder. |
| 2 | What I am unsure about | I'm unsure which template to use. |
| 3 | What I need | Could you confirm operations or finance template? |
| 4 | What happens next | Once confirmed, I can complete the draft by Friday. |

Challenge 4: Ask the Manager

Practice 2–3 clarifying questions in pairs.

Your manager says: “Can you put together a short update for next week’s project review?” You are not sure what “short” means, who the audience is, or what format is expected.

- Person A = intern
- Person B = manager
- Ask about audience, format, scope, deadline, next step

Pairs • 5 minutes

Feedback + Follow-Up

Feedback is information you can use, not a personal failure.

Acknowledge

Thank you for the feedback.

Clarify

Could you confirm which section needs the most revision?

Act

I'll update it and send the revised version by Friday.

Learn

I'll use this structure for future reports.

Challenge 5: Choose the best response

Your manager says: “This update is useful, but too detailed for the leadership meeting.”

A. “Oh, sorry. I didn’t know. I’ll fix it.”

B. “I included the details because I thought they were important.”

C. “Thank you. I’ll revise it to focus on the key decision points. Could you confirm if you want it limited to one page?”

D. “Okay.”

Your 30-Day Communication Commitment

One habit I will improve

One situation where I will use CLEAR

One question I will ask my manager

One action I will take after feedback

Complete your worksheet



Take CLEAR back to work

Use this checklist before sending a manager update.

- | | |
|-------------------|--|
| Context | Have I named the situation or task? |
| Lead | Is the main point easy to find? |
| Explain | Did I include only useful detail? |
| Ask/Action | Is the request or next step clear? |
| Recap | Did I confirm owner, timing, or follow-up? |

When in doubt: make it easier for the reader to decide, respond, or act.

Clarity builds confidence.

You do not need perfect wording every time.
Communicate with structure, respect, and ownership.

Thank you

